I am Nujood, Age 10 and Divorced

By Nujood Ali and Delphine Minoui

Suggested for performance by a young female student of middle-eastern descent. A middle eastern dialect example can be found at http://www.dialectsarchive.com/saudi-arabia-4

It was in Yemen, an extraordinary and turbulent country, barely ten years ago, that a little girl named Nujood was born.

A tiny wisp of a thing, Nujood is neither a queen nor a princess. She is a normal girl with parents and plenty of brothers and sisters. Like all children her age, she loves to play hide-and-seek and adores chocolate. She likes to make colored drawings and fantasizes about being a sea turtle, because she has never seen the ocean. When she smiles, a tiny dimple appears in her left cheek.

One cold and gray February evening in 2008, however, that appealing and mischievous grin suddenly melted into bitter tears when her father told her that she was going to wed a man three times her age. It was as if the whole world had landed on her shoulders. Hastily married off a few days later, the little girl resolved to gather all her strength and try to escape her miserable fate . . .

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INTRODUCTION

With harrowing directness, Nujood tells of abuse at her husband's hands and of her daring escape. With the help of local advocates and the press, Nujood obtained her freedom—an extraordinary achievement in Yemen, where almost half of all girls are married under the legal age. I am Nujood, Age 10 and Divorced by Nujood Ali and Delphine Minoui

NUJOOD: In Khardji, the village in Yemen where I was born, women are not taught how to make choices. When she was about 16, Shoya, my mother, married my father without protest. And when he decided four years later to choose a second wife, my mother obediently accepted his decision. It was with that same resignation that I at first agreed to my marriage, without realizing what was at stake. At my age, you don't ask yourself many questions.

One February evening in 2008, Aba—Papa—told me he had some good news.

PAPA: Nujood, you are to be married.

NUJOOD: The news came out of nowhere. I didn't really understand. At first I felt almost relieved because life at home had become impossible. Aba had never been able to find full-time employment after losing his street-sweeper job, so we were always late with the rent. Aba was spending his afternoons chewing khat with neighbors. He claimed it helped him forget his troubles. It was during one of those khat sessions that a man of about 30 had approached him.

THAMER: I would like our families to be united

NUJOOD: . . . the man had said. His name was Faez Ali Thamer, and he worked as a deliveryman. My father accepted his proposal.

PAPA: It's the best way to protect her. She won't be raped by a stranger and become the prey of evil rumors. This man seems honest. He has promised not to touch Nujood until she's older. Besides, we haven't enough money to feed the whole family.

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NUJOOD: My wedding preparations moved rapidly ahead, and I soon realized my misfortune when my future husband's family decided that I must leave school. I loved school. It was my refuge, a happiness all my own.

In the back of the SUV waiting in front of our door, a short man was staring at me. He wore a long white zanna and had a mustache. His short wavy hair was mussed, and his face was poorly shaved. He was not handsome. This was Faez Ali Thamer!

When the motor rumbled to life and the driver pulled away, I started crying, silently, with my face to the window as I watched Omma grow smaller and smaller.

How relieved I felt when they led me to my room. A long woven mat was lying on the floor: my bed. I didn't even need to put out the light to fall asleep. When the door crashed open, I was startled awake. I'd barely opened my eyes when I felt a damp, hairy body pressing against me.

"Please, I'm begging you, leave me alone," I gasped.

THAMER: You are my wife!

NUJOOD: I leaped to my feet. The door was not completely closed, and spying a glimmer of light, I dashed toward the courtyard. "Help! Help!" I shrieked, sobbing. My voice rang in the night, but it was as if I were shouting into a void. I ran, panting for breath -- arms caught me, held me tightly, wrestled me back into the bedroom, pushed me down on the mat. I felt paralyzed, as if I had been tied down.

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When he took off his tunic, I rolled into a ball to protect myself, but he began pulling at my nightshirt. He started to laugh, nastily.

THAMER: You are my wife. Now you must do what I want!

NUJOOD: Suddenly it was as if I'd been snatched up by a hurricane, flung around, struck by lightning, and I had no more strength to fight back. Something burning invaded the deepest part of me. No matter how I screamed, no one came to help me. It hurt, awfully. I shrieked one more time, I think, then lost consciousness.

I had to adjust quickly to a new life. I had no right to leave the house, no right to complain, no right to say no. During the day, I had to obey my mother-in-law's orders: Cut up the vegetables, wash the floor, do the dishes. Whenever I stopped for a moment, my mother-in-law pulled my hair.

He left every morning and returned right before sunset. Each time I heard him arrive, the same panic seized my heart. When night fell, I knew what would begin again. The same savagery, the same pain and distress. On the third day, he began hitting me, first with his hands, then with a stick. And his mother egged him on. Whenever he would complain about me, she would tell him,

MOTHER-IN-LAW: Hit her even harder. She must listen to you—she's your wife.

NUJOOD: I lived in permanent fear. Whenever I could, I would hide in a corner, lost and bewildered. One morning, worn down by all my crying, he told me he would allow me to visit my parents. At last!

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PAPA: Nujood, you are a married woman now. You must stay with your husband. If you divorce your husband, my brothers and cousins will kill me! Honor comes first.

NUJOOD: I went to see Dowla, my father's second wife, who lived with her five children in a tiny apartment across from our street. I poured out my heart to her, and my story seemed to affect her deeply.

DOWLA: (whispering) Nujood, if no one will listen to you, you must go straight to court. Ask to see the judge—his job is to help victims.

NUJOOD: My head is spinning—In the yard outside the courthouse, a crowd is bustling in every direction. No one sees me: I'm too small. I'm only ten years old, maybe not even that. Who knows?

Trembling, I latch on to the first passing veil, hoping to get the attention of the woman it conceals. "I want to talk to the judge." Two big eyes framed in black stare at me in surprise.

"Follow me," the woman finally says. The door opens onto a room full of people, and at the far end, behind a desk, a thin-faced man with a mustache. It's the judge at last.

JUDGE: And what can I do for you?

NUJOOD: It is a curiously gentle voice. "I want a divorce."

JUDGE: At your age? How can you already be married? And why do you want a divorce?

NUJOOD: I look him straight in the eye. "Because my husband beats me."

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It's as if I had slapped him in the face. His expression freezes again. Point-blank, he asks me,

JUDGE: Are you still a virgin?

NUJOOD: I swallow hard. I'm ashamed of talking about these things. But in that same instant, I understand that if I want to win, I must. "No. I bled."

He's shocked. I can see his surprise, see him trying to conceal his emotions. Then he takes a deep breath and says,

JUDGE: I'm going to help you.

NUJOOD: I feel relieved. I watch him grab his phone with his shaking hand. With luck, he'll act quickly, and this evening, I'll be able to go home to my parents and play with my brothers and sisters, just like before. Divorced! Without that dread of finding myself alone, at nightfall, in the same bedroom with him.

A second judge joins us in the room, and he dashes my enthusiasm to bits.

JUDGE 2: My child, this might very well take a lot more time than you think. And unfortunately, I cannot promise that you will win.

NUJOOD: He says he has never seen a case like mine, because no little girl has, until now, showed up at a courthouse. . . . Do they realize that if I go home without any guarantee, my husband will come get me, and the torture will start all over again?

"I want to get divorced!" I frown fiercely to show I mean it. The sound of my own voice makes me jump.

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JUDGE 2: According to Yemeni law, it is difficult for you to file a complaint against your husband and your father

NUJOOD: Like many children born in Yemeni villages, I didn't have a birth certificate, and I was too young to initiate proceedings against anyone. A contract had been signed and approved by the men of my family. According to Yemeni tradition, it was valid.

JUDGE 2: For the moment we must act quickly. I suggest we place Nujood's father and husband under temporary arrest. If we want to protect her, it's better to have them in prison than at liberty."

NUJOOD: Prison! Would Aba ever forgive me? I was consumed with shame and guilt.

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NUJOOD: The great day has arrived. The courtroom is full—I have never seen so many cameras. Beneath my black scarf, I'm perspiring heavily. Deep down I feel frozen solid, unable to move. Just how does a divorce happen? What if the monster simply says no? If he begins threatening the judge?

I shiver: I recognize Aba and . . . the monster, escorted by two soldiers. The prisoners look furious. I find myself staring into Aba's eyes. He seems so upset. "Honor," he had said. Seeing his face, I begin to understand what that very complicated word means. I can see in my Aba's eyes that he's angry and ashamed at the same time. I'm so furious at him, but I can't help feeling sorry for him too. The respect of other men—that's so important here.

It's the judge's turn to speak.

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JUDGE: Listen to me carefully. You married this little girl two months ago, you slept with her, you struck her. Is that true, yes or no?"

NUJOOD: I hold my breath. The monster blinks, then replies,

THAMER: Yes, But I was gentle with her, I was careful. I did not beat her.

NUJOOD: His answer is like a slap in the face, reminding me of all those other slaps, the insults, the suffering. "That's not true!" I yell, beside myself with anger.

Everyone turns to look at me. But I'm the first to be astonished at my outburst. In the end, I am saved by the judge's verdict.

JUDGE: The divorce is granted.

NUJOOD: My divorce has changed my life. When I go out in the street, sometimes women call to me, congratulating me. I recently returned to live with my parents. We all seem to be pretending to have forgotten what happened. My nightmares stopped a few weeks ago. Instead, I've been dreaming about school. When I grow up, I'll be a lawyer, to defend other little girls like me.

Update: In April 2009, the Yemeni parliament raised the legal age of consent to 17, but it was overturned the next day. Today, Yemen is in political turmoil, and men can take brides of any age.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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